

Most Frequent Pitfalls in Tech Sourcing

By Chris Walker, Tech Recruitment Lead – Carter Wellington

This is the most important part of this training.
The patterns below consistently determine whether a candidate is placeable, difficult, or an automatic reject for most clients.

Common Red Flags We See

Job hopping

This is the #1 red flag for most clients. Candidates repeatedly leaving roles before the 12-month mark signal risk.

If you believe a candidate is still strong, ensure the reasons are clearly explained and contextualised, but represent profiles like this sparingly.

Contract roles (US clients)

A major red flag for many US clients, particularly when contract work dominates the resume.

Technical consulting backgrounds (US clients)

Another frequent concern. Many clients prefer candidates who have built and owned products internally rather than delivered work via consulting models.

Bootcamp-only backgrounds (especially <3 YOE)

Most clients still expect a formal university degree in a relevant discipline. Bootcamp candidates can work, but only when explicitly requested by the client.

Years of Experience misalignment

Always validate graduation year against claimed YOE.

As a general guide:

- 2020 graduates ≈ 5 YOE
- 2019 graduates ≈ 6 YOE
- Misalignment here is an immediate credibility issue.

Real Candidate Examples

All examples below are real profiles reviewed by Carter Wellington. Some job details have been swapped to maintain anonymity.

Candidates are ranked from 1 (not placeable) to 4 (very placeable).

Candidate #1 – Not Placeable (1/4)

Profile

- Lead Full Stack Developer @ JP Morgan Chase (11 months)
- Full Stack Developer @ LTMindtree (7 months)
- Senior Developer @ Tata Consultancy (3 years 10 months)
- Rajasthan Technical University

Why we do not represent profiles like this

- Heavy consulting background
- Prior contract-style experience
- Weak tenure with multiple short stays
- This is close to an auto-reject for most clients.

Candidate #2 – Difficult to Place (2/4)

Profile

- Software Engineer @ New York Times (3 years 9 months)
- Software Engineer @ Citi (9 months)
- Master's in Computer Science @ Tufts
- Bootcamp education

We placed this candidate, but it required significant effort and careful role selection.

Actual hiring manager feedback

- No CS undergraduate degree
- NYT perceived as a media company, not a tech company
- No prior experience at a pure technology firm
- If you see a profile like this, calibrate with the client first before submitting.

Placeable Candidates

From this point on, these are the profiles you should actively look to represent.

Candidate #3 – Placeable (3/4)

Profile

- Software Engineer II @ Amazon (5 years)
- Bachelor's in Computer Science @ Harvard

Strong signals:

- Top-tier CS education
- FAANG experience

Caution

Candidates who have worked only in big tech can struggle with startup-focused roles.

Best approach

Submit to roles open to big-tech backgrounds

Avoid roles explicitly requiring startup experience

Candidate #4 – Placeable (3/4)

Profile

- Software Engineer @ Rippling (4 years)
- Senior Data Engineer @ Altitude Networks (1 year)
- Data Scientist @ Bank of the West (1 year)
- Data Analyst @ Investment Firm (9 months)
- Without Rippling, this would be a 2/4.
- A strong logo combined with solid tenure can override earlier yellow flags.

Candidate #5 – Very Placeable (4/4)

Profile

- Senior Software Engineer @ Snorkel AI (1 year)
- Software Engineer @ Discord (2 years)
- Software Engineer @ Amazon (1 year)
- Computer Science @ UC Berkeley

This is a highly attractive profile:

- Big tech experience
- High-bar engineering environment
- Startup exposure
- Top university

Candidates like this deserve time, multiple role submissions, and proactive representation.

Candidate #6 – Very Placeable (4/4)

Profile

- Senior Software Engineer @ Startup #1 (8 months)
- Founder @ Startup #2 (acquired, 8 months)
- Bachelor's and Master's in Computer Science @ Stanford
- Despite short tenures, this candidate was one of the most in-demand profiles reviewed.

Why this works

- Elite CS education with strong academic performance
- Founder and acquisition experience
- Proven ability to operate in startup environments

This example reinforces a core principle we teach at Carter Wellington: Red flags can be outweighed by clear, undeniable signals of excellence.

Final Takeaway

Not every imperfect candidate should be rejected, but only exceptional signals justify taking that risk.

Your role is to apply judgment, calibrate with clients, and represent candidates who can realistically convert into offers.

Use this checklist before any client submission.

If a candidate fails multiple No-Go criteria without strong counter-signals, they should not be represented.

1. Tenure & Stability

GO

- At least one role with 18–36+ months tenure
- Clear, logical reasons for any short stays
- Evidence of ownership over meaningful work

NO-GO

- Multiple roles under 12 months with no compelling explanation
- Pattern of reactive job moves
- History suggests flight risk

2. Company Quality & Signal Strength

GO

- Experience at recognisable tech firms, strong startups, or high-bar teams
- Logos that hiring managers instantly trust
- Clear explanation of company context and impact

NO-GO

- Unknown or low-signal companies with no differentiation
- Inflated titles unsupported by company scale
- Inability to articulate why the company mattered

3. Product Ownership vs Delivery

GO

- Built, owned, and maintained production systems
- Accountable for outcomes, not just tasks
- Demonstrated end-to-end responsibility

NO-GO

- Pure delivery or ticket-based execution

- Primarily consulting or staff-augmentation backgrounds
- No long-term ownership of systems

4. Experience Mix (Big Tech / Startup)

GO

- Exposure to both scale and ambiguity
- Big tech + startup experience is ideal
- Clear understanding of trade-offs between environments

NO-GO

- Only consulting environments
- Only big tech with no adaptability signal
- Only early startups with no scale exposure

5. Education & Foundations

GO

- CS or closely related degree
- Strong university or academically rigorous program
- Education aligns with claimed technical depth

NO-GO

- Bootcamp-only background where degree is required
- Education misrepresented or unclear
- Weak fundamentals masked by buzzwords

6. Career Progression & Trajectory

GO

- Promotions, scope growth, or expanded responsibility
- Logical narrative from role to role
- Growth within the same company

NO-GO

- Flat trajectory over many years
- Title inflation without responsibility increase
- Career story feels random or reactive

7. YOE Credibility Check

GO

- Graduation year aligns with claimed experience
- Experience timeline is realistic and defensible
- No exaggerated seniority

NO-GO

- Inflated YOE
- Timeline inconsistencies
- Senior titles too early in career

8. Engineering Bar & Selectivity

GO

- Passed selective hiring processes
- Worked in environments with strong peer review
- Comfortable discussing technical trade-offs

NO-GO

- No evidence of screening or quality bar
- Avoids depth in technical discussions
- Relies on tools or frameworks without understanding

9. Ambiguity & Autonomy

GO

- Comfortable working with incomplete requirements
- History of problem-solving without heavy direction
- Evidence of initiative and judgment

NO-GO

- Requires heavy structure and oversight
- Struggles outside rigid processes
- Avoids responsibility for decisions

10. Communication & Interview Readiness

GO

- Clear, confident articulation of work and impact
- Strong narrative linking experience to role
- Can engage both technical and non-technical stakeholders

NO-GO

- Rambling or unclear explanations
- Cannot explain decisions or trade-offs
- Weak or defensive interview presence

Final Submission Rule

GO if:

- Candidate meets most GO criteria
- Any red flags are outweighed by strong, credible signals
- You would confidently defend this profile to a hiring manager

NO-GO if:

- Multiple no-go signals with no excellence offset
- You feel the need to “hope” the client overlooks gaps
- If you wouldn’t stake your credibility on the submission, don’t submit.